

SELF-ESTEEM

Greetings my dearest friends. Blessings for every one of you here. May your heart be open, may your attention be focused so that you can absorb as much as possible in this hour.

In this last lecture of the year, I should like to discuss a problem of great importance, especially for all those whose pathwork has brought them into contact and awareness with heretofore undetected reactions in the self. These reactions indicate struggle and confusion. It is the entire question of self-esteem, which is of such fundamental importance. Self-esteem or self-liking or self-value -- whatever name you may give it -- is sorely lacking in every human being who experiences uncertainty, fear, insecurity, guilt, weakness, doubt, negativity, feelings of inadequacy and inferiority. To whatever degree any of these feelings or attitudes are present, to that degree self-esteem is inevitably lacking, only it is not directly recognized as such. And that is all the more damaging for the person, for he is then less capable of tackling the problem directly. Only considerable insight into the self, as a result of hard work, brings this direct awareness, "I do not like and respect myself."

Man is constantly confronted with an inner and rarely conscious conflict in this respect. The conflict arises out of the dualistic perception, characteristic of mankind. I have shown in several instances in the past how misconception splits a truth into two opposing halves which confuse man and make it impossible for him to make satisfying choices. He is then torn in inner dissension and painful confusion. In this case, the dilemma is how can you accept and like yourself without falling into the danger of self-indulgence and self-justification for the destructive traits that exist in all human beings, no matter how concealed they may be? Or, on the other side of this conflict, how can you confront and accept and admit those negative, destructive traits, those weaknesses for which you feel inadequate, those little selfishnesses and cruelties, those little vanities that often make you vindictive and unloving? How can you confront, accept, acknowledge them, and nevertheless not lose your self-respect? How can you not fall into the danger of destructive guilt and self-negation, of self-rejection and self-contempt? This is a deep-rooted conflict, and most human beings, whether or not they know it, battle with this very profound question. It is a profound human predicament and a typical dualistic confusion, which makes admitting an unpleasant truth and self-acceptance apparently two mutually exclusive opposites.

This is an immensely important question, for which I will try to give some answers and suggestions so that you can deal with this problem in your own mind and feelings and perhaps finally come to a solution. But before I will discuss this in greater detail and offer you a key that will make it possible to unify this split, let me discuss a little more the conflict itself. Those of you who have recently found this raging battle within yourselves will know exactly what I am talking about here. Others, who have not yet realized and seen their self-rejection, will have to come to this awareness in the gradual way this path leads them to. Perhaps the only way you can now recognize

your self-dislike and your underevaluation of your person will be indirectly. As I mentioned before, you can surely sense shyness, uncertainty, insecurity, apprehension about being rejected or criticized, about feelings of inferiority and inadequacy. Perhaps you may perceive here or there a peculiar guilt feeling that makes rationally no sense to you. Although this guilt may usually hide behind other attitudes, it is rarely so remote that it cannot be clearly perceived at times once your mind sets out to detect such things. Perhaps you are aware of the fact that you are not open towards the untold possibilities of blissful fulfillment in life, that you make do with much less than you could experience in an unnecessarily modest and limited way. Perhaps you can discern that you stand back in life and vaguely feel undeserving and perceive life negatively as far as your own possibilities are concerned. Perhaps this exists only in certain areas of life's fulfillments, but it still suffices to indicate self-rejection. Any and all of these manifestations indicate self-rejection, self-dislike. It should not be too difficult to bridge the gap of consciousness between any of these manifestations with the more profound root, namely that you do not think much of yourself. You may dislike yourself for one or several specific traits and attitudes, but this specificity may be even more hidden from your awareness. It is quite possible that you can first ascertain only the vague general feeling of self-disdain without being able to pinpoint it. Once you feel the general and vague feeling that you do not respect your person, that you lack esteem and appreciation for yourself as a human being, the next step must then be to set out to make this attitude toward yourself more specific. Once you really want to find it, you will do so although it may come quite indirectly and as though the knowledge of the specific reason for self-rejection came via an altogether different route. This is the way the path often works.

On the other hand, you may see something quite clearly that is truly regrettable and undesirable. Then you may fall into the erroneous attitude of being defiant and justifying yourself because you believe that by admitting your undesirable traits you must dislike and reject your entire person. You cannot differentiate, as I have often pointed out in the past, between rejecting a trait and rejecting the person (with yourself and others). Therefore you fall into the error of justifying, denying, falsifying, and rationalizing -- and often even beautifying -- a very undesirable and destructive trait.

Here you have this confusion -- full-fledged! To find the key which enables you to squarely confront the undesirable attitudes without in the least losing respect for yourself or losing the sense that you are a valuable human being, the following considerations are necessary. First, I wish to say here that you have to perceive and experience the phenomenon of life in a new way. Life -- and you are life because you are alive -- the life that you are, is representative of all life, of nature. One of the earmarks of life is its untold potentialities for change and expansion. To be more specific, you can take any human being -- no matter how destructive, no matter how low in his development -- and once you perceive of life as it is, you will sense that even in this lowliest of all destructive creatures, all possibilities for change and for goodness, for greatness and for growth exist. Any minute, the thinking may change and will then create new attitudes of behavior and actions, new feelings, new ways of being. And if it does not happen now, that alters nothing either, for one day it is bound to change because man's true nature must finally emerge. This knowledge of man's, or life's, true nature having to emerge sooner or later, changes everything. It changes your despair about yourself. It opens the door to knowing of your potentials, your possibilities for goodness regardless of how malicious you may be; for generosity regardless of how mean you may now be; for lovingness regardless of how selfish you may be; of strength and integrity regardless of how weak you may now be and how tempted to betray your best self; for greatness regardless of how petty you may now be.

You look at nature and at any manifestation of life, and it is forever changing; it is forever dying and being born; it is forever expanding and contracting and pulsating. It is always moving and branching out, perpetually. This applies particularly to life where it is conscious and even more so where it is self-conscious. The power of thought, the power of will, the power of emotions is infinitely greater than any inanimate power. And yet, the inanimate power of, say, electricity and even more of atomic energy is so great that you, in your world, begin to gain only an inkling of its possibilities, for good and constructive ends as well as for destructive ones. Wherever there is life and consciousness, these two possibilities exist. Now, if in the smallest atom -- a measurement that cannot even be perceived with the naked eye -- exists a power to release untold energies for building or destroying, how infinitely more this is the case with the power of the mind. The power of thinking, feeling, and willing. Just dwell on this significant fact, my friends, and it will open new vistas to you. Why does man blindly assume that the power of inanimate things is greater than the power of the mind?

The power to think, will, and feel, to express, act, and decide is the most distinguishing earmark of consciousness. The power all these expressions of consciousness yields is vastly underrated by mankind. Living consciousness deserves, therefore, such a respect as can hardly be put into words. It does not matter in what way it manifests, no matter how undesirable and destructive the present manifestation may be, the life that issues forth from the momentary destructiveness holds all the potentials for turning the same powers that now work destructively, into constructive channels -- and even more so. For life's source is truly inexhaustible.

Since the very essence of life is movement and therefore change, this is what justifiably and realistically gives hope, no matter how hopeless a situation or a state of mind may appear to be. He who is in a deep depression and hopelessness must be in error, for he negates the very essence of life. And he who despairs about himself because he feels he is so bad, because he feels certain aspects of himself are so unacceptable, so destructive, so negative, finds himself in the error of perceiving and experiencing life in a fixed way as though what is now must always be. This is the error of deadness and the error of a consciousness steeped in rigid, fixed deadness, "This is so, and that is that, and this is all there is to it." It ignores and negates the flux of true life. Since you are alive, this fluidity is yours. In reality, you are fluid. The only thing that keeps you from being fluid and therefore changing into a state of realistic hopefulness and light, the essence of life itself, is your own enclosure, your ignorance of this truth -- your momentary state of consciousness.

This state of consciousness is now fixed in the conviction that life is static, that what is, is unmoving and must remain that way, so also your personality traits. Your state of consciousness remains fixed in this dark imprisonment as long as you know of nothing else. By the mere fact of your being here and hearing these words, you have the possibility to apply them to your personal situation. Where are you hopeless? Why are you hopeless? Do you feel hopeless because of life itself? because you believe the possibilities for expansion and happiness are too limited to give you sufficient scope? And/or are you hopeless because you feel you do not deserve and cannot have a more meaningful fulfilled experience of life? The latter may smolder secretly underneath your perception of life's limitations.

If you can make these fleeting impressions into more concise awareness, you can bring to bear what I said here and question yourself in the following way. Are you hopeless about your being

undeserving of happiness because you, possibly quite justifiably, dislike certain traits and aspects in you? But do you then not believe that these traits and aspects are "it," that they mark and define your person? That is the great struggle, my friends, because you erroneously believe that that which is most obnoxious to you is you. This, at the same time, is the cause for the great resistance inherent in all human beings against changing. For, since you do not believe that you can essentially be anything else but that which you dislike, you have to hold on to it nevertheless because you do not wish to cease existing. This is the crux of this dualistic confusion. This is why you so inexplicably hold on to destructive traits. Many of my friends have reached the awareness where they can see this and actually recognize and see themselves holding on to facets of themselves they thoroughly dislike. They seem unable to help it and thus despair even more. They cannot even understand what power propels them to almost deliberately hold on to what they hate in themselves.

Here, my friends, is the answer. You hold on to it because you genuinely believe this is you, believe you are a fixed state, you are a fixed unit, and any change is impossible because you do not realize that all possibilities exist in you in infinite versions. You are already that which you think you would have to produce artificially, laboriously, and through contorting your very nature. But since you do not believe this, you cannot give up holding on to the very facets you do dislike, for they seem to represent your essence of being.

This is indeed a vicious circle, for true self-esteem can of course only come by your sensing your capacities to love, to give of yourself. Yet this capacity cannot be known when you take it blindly for granted that it simply does not exist, when you believe that any other state than the one you express now is alien to you, intrinsically alien, and your real, true, final, fixed self is that which you dislike. As long as that is your case, you must be in a hopeless vicious circle.

In order to come out of it, life in its essence must be understood. No matter how fixed it may appear, it is only one tiny part of the whole story, my friends. Underneath all these personality aspects you believe are fixed, final things, the fluid life exists -- a life in which change is constant, in which feelings branch out in all directions spontaneously and wondrously forever self-renewing; a life in which there is vibrant pulsation, that is movement in itself; above all, a life in which you are free at any moment to think new and different thoughts that are the creators of a new and different life expression and personality.

You see, as long as you deny and ignore the true state of life, hence also the true state for yourself, you cannot give yourself the fundamental essential respect that you deserve as a human creature. As long as you confuse life with death, with inanimate matter, you must despair about yourself. And even in inanimate matter, as you now know through present day science, exists an intrinsic life and an incredible movement once this life is released. Think of this, my friends. Even an apparently dead object is not dead; it contains life, movement, and utter change. Think of the movement, life, and change in every atom of the deadest seeming matter.

So, nothing in the universe actually exists that is lifeless -- how much less so with consciousness! Your thinking is a constant movement. The only trouble is that you have conditioned yourself to let it ruminate in conditioned reflexes of habitual negativity, self-rejection, and needless limitation. But once you decide to use your thinking in a new way, you will experience the truth of life's hopeful changeability, its endless possibilities to move into new directions. You can constantly expand your thinking, take in new ideas, embrace new realizations, and therefore

bring to yourself new light and life, and therefore bring new will-directions, new expansions, new aims, new energies, new feelings. All of this is personality change. Without you first being quite aware of it, these new ways of thinking, consequently of feeling, will change those attitudes you now dislike so much.

When I say new, I want to make it quite clear here that this does not mean it has not existed in you as a dormant essence of your very being. It is only new as far as your awareness is concerned. For it is all there, constantly ready to be used for the asking. But as long as you enclose yourself into this narrow framework of your limited ideas and perceptions of yourself and life, the longer you cannot utilize what is constantly there. Perceive yourself as fertile soil into which no seeds are put as yet. Fertile soil contains constantly this incredible power to bring forth new expressions of life. The potentials seethe in it whether or not the seeds are actually put in. Your entire consciousness and aliveness is the most fertile soil imaginable. The fertile soil is constantly there with an incredible power to bring forth new expressions of life -- and that is all that you are: your thinking, your feeling, your willing, your energies, your powers, your forces, your possibilities of action and reaction. Each situation you are in contains new possibilities to react. You have choices all the time. You can be in a situation and automatically fall into the old conditioned reflexes, your negative approach, without paying attention to what you are doing. And perhaps then you moan about the misery of life because this and that has happened to you which you do not like, and you never see the connection between your discontent, unhappiness, and failures, on the one hand, and your one-sided, negative automatic reactions, on the other. As long as you assume that this habitual approach is the only one possible, you will not grasp the possibilities and powers of the life you represent.

Thus when you find yourself in an unhappy or hopeless state, question yourself, "Do I not have another possibility of reacting to this very same situation that seems to befall me out of nowhere, and which I chose to react to in a negative, destructive way, and to make myself hopeless about it, to complain about it, to feel angry about it?" This choice is yours. Your anger and complaint against the world is wasted, for all the energy could do so much to build new life for you if it were used in the proper way. As I said to you so often and many years ago, you cannot change others, but you certainly can change your own attitudes and your thinking processes and styles. Then life offers its limitless possibilities to you.

First, your thinking and your attitudes change; then the feelings follow suit; then your actions and reactions begin to respond to new spontaneous impulses. And this in turn brings forth new life experiences. The more you experience the chain reaction of this process, the more you also perceive that you are a living, moving, endlessly changing unit of life expression. And no trait deserves that you reject, dislike, and evaluate your whole self because of it. Once you perceive this, you can afford the wonderful, relieving luxury, if I may say, to calmly admit any undesirable, ugly trait without in the least disliking yourself for it, without in the least losing your sense of being a divine expression, no matter what the traits may be. And then and then only can you really overcome the traits because, paradoxical as this may seem, the total self-rejection, the destructive kind of guilt under discussion, is incapable of overcoming anything. You will not understand why, my friends, unless you see that it is impossible to overcome anything when you believe you are a fixed, unchangeable blob in creation. You know that, according to your belief, you must experience as long as you thus believe, because your vision cannot see beyond the form you have built according to your belief. And your actions

are determined by it and must thus provide proof of the veracity of this belief, no matter how unnecessary it is and how many other alternatives exist.

Thus if you are convinced that you cannot change, you cannot even make a meaningful step in the direction of change. Therefore you cannot experience change and must be convinced that change is impossible. The negative conviction makes it also impossible to summon the necessary effort for bringing change about. The energy, the discipline, the stamina, the initiative essential for effecting a change will be comparatively easy to muster when you know a change is possible, when you know that change merely means bringing out your dormant qualities that already exist in you. When you know that, no matter how ugly the traits may be, you will not despair about being an unlovable individual. You will make available the powers in you to surge forward. You will be able to dip into the sources of your innermost being that make the resources available to overcome an ugly, destructive trait.

The power that created the universe, with everything in it, including all that you are, possesses the strength to change anything. For even that which should be changed was created by that same power and must in its essence be something else than it appears now. This power is also you and is manifest once you contact it deliberately. This can be done only when you know of the source within you, the source of life that is forever changing, forever moving, forever expanding with infinite possibilities.

You see, my friends, the life that is inherent in nature is also in you. Only the feeling life, the natural life, can indeed bring you the fulfillment without which life is a sorry affair indeed. A pure will and intellectual life is barren, as you well know. This is what we have been talking about and aiming for on this path all the years we have been together. Now why has mankind lost touch with the source of its own life, the source of feelings, the source of instincts, the source of its own nature, deep inside the self? This has happened only because mankind is so terrified of its destructiveness and has not known how to handle it. So, civilization has for millennia denied the instinctual life in order to preserve itself from its dangers. But it ignored that denial, and by doing so, it has cut off its connection with the essence of life itself. It has not known that there are other ways to eliminate the distorted, perverted, erroneous natural forces, which need not deny life itself. The instinctual life has always been wrongly equated with destructiveness. Only as mankind grows more mature is it capable of learning that the instinctual life does not need to be denied in order to avoid evil, indeed, should not be denied, for doing so defeats life every bit as much as the feared evil itself. Only within the core of the instincts can God be found because only there can true aliveness be found. Thus mankind must find another means to handle its destructive instincts if it is not to annihilate itself by ways different but just as fatal as giving vent to those negative instincts would be.

What I said in this lecture will give you an additional tool to meet the destructive side in you. You will learn to value and nurture the deep instincts you have always so distrusted and to find the truth of the living creative spirit in and through them. You will then joyfully further your instinctual life, unfold, and integrate it. You will believe and trust in it. Do not deny and fear it because you have as yet difficulties in accepting and meeting the undesirable destructive traits of your character. If you truly look at them in a dispassionate, objective way, you will always find that these traits really oppose the life of the instincts. The latter is simple and innocent in itself; your destructiveness is always a result of pride, self-will, fear, vanity, greed, separateness, lovelessness, one-upmanship.

In this way, you will find it more and more possible to meet, acknowledge, admit, and accept anything in you, no matter how ugly, and never lose for one second the sense of your intrinsic beautiful liveness and of deserving your own esteem. This will be the springboard from which change will become possible. It will not only be a possibility in the abstract, but it will be an effective way of living day in and day out, a constantly growing movement.

This is such an important topic, and any one of you who can truly bring it to bear upon the state wherever you are at this moment will fulfill the next step on this path and will overcome an important hurdle. There are many of you who may be stuck just because of this painful inner confusion. Some of you may not know this consciously; others may feel it vaguely; still others may be quite aware of this struggle. Most human beings are totally oblivious of the fact that this very same battle rages in them, that this battle has created the instinctual restrictions and fears, the self-alienation, the aridness and impoverishment of the souls who cannot thrive in a climate of self-rejection. They also ignore that all the religious commands to love cannot be fulfilled until this dualistic split is healed and unification found so that self-liking is no longer confused with self-indulgence and honest self-confrontation need not bring self-loathing. You can find peace only when you can truly accept the ugliest in you and never lose sight of your intrinsic beauty.

Now, are there any questions?

QUESTION: In relation to my self-esteem, I feel a terrific battle going on right now. It feels like an atomic explosion, in terms of an image. I realize I'm stuck as to my own limitations, as to the two sides in me. And also, I realize that I can't stand pleasure. Coming from my habitual state of displeasure, the state of pleasure almost seems unnatural.

ANSWER: If you can conceive of yourself as the essence of life with all its incredible powers, possibilities, and inherent potentials, as a forever changing expression of life, you will indeed know that you are deserving of your own esteem and acceptance. You will be able to see the traits you hate and still not lose sight of the fact who you essentially are. I also suggest a specific little exercise you might find quite helpful. Put down in writing everything that you dislike about yourself. Have it down in black and white. Look at those traits when they are written down. Then feel into yourself and ask: "Do I really believe that this is all there is to me? Do I really believe that I must be these traits all my life? Do I believe I have the possibility to love? Do I hold forces locked up in me that contain all the good imaginable?" By raising these questions seriously, you will get an answer on a deeply feeling level, a level where the answer is more than a theoretical concept. You will experience a new power in you that you do not need to fear, and a new gentleness and softness that does not need hostility or other defenses. Then you will know how much there is in you to love and respect.

You have recently come across, in your personal pathwork, a very specific misconception that makes loving impossible as long as you harbor this false idea. Since loving represents the terrible danger of being totally impoverished, even robbed of your very life, how can you want to love? How can you let yourself love? According to this false idea, giving of yourself means losing what you give without it ever being replenished. If this were true, love would indeed be impossible and giving, a folly. Is it now conceivable for you to see that this is not so, that reality is different? And if you can see that love comes from the same inexhaustible well as wisdom, as all of life does, can you further perceive that you will not need to deny your own natural instinct that wants to reach out,

that wants the pleasure of feeling love, warmth, and giving of yourself? And can you still foresee the next natural, organic step in the chain, which is that if you can love, you will inevitably love yourself? This is the reason that you fear pleasure. For pleasure not only seems entirely undeserved, it is, above all, that love and pleasure are interchangeable. True pleasure is loving, and without loving, pleasure just does not exist. This is not a reward from outside or even from your own self; it is that love is pleasure, and pleasure is love. The two are interchangeable. If you harbor love feelings, your whole body is in a blissful vibration, with certainty, with security, with peace, with stimulation, with excitement in the most relaxed, pleasurable way. That cannot come through anything that is given to you and where you are merely a recipient. It comes when you vibrate with this feeling. Nor does this mean that you do not also receive love. The giving and receiving become so interchangeable that it can often no longer be discerned which is which. Both become indistinguishable as one movement.

But if your nature is as yet incapable of allowing the feeling of love, you must fear bliss since bliss and loving are one and the same thing. The misconception that giving is losing causes you to close up and contract in all situations which might bring forth your natural instincts. When you deny love and pleasure, you must inevitably also deny your self-esteem. Your key must lie in the fact that your inability to love is not an inborn aspect that you, alone, harbor forever. It is a temporary block, based on some false premises of thinking on a deeper level of your emotional experience. You can change this misconception any moment you truly and fully look at it.

Be blessed, every one of you here. Be in peace, be what you are, honestly and truly so that God in you manifests more and more.

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